brings. Besides, in any case, he has given up running races.' Hearing this, Krishna Menon burst out laughing, but General Thimayya was not amused, though there was little he could do to circumvent a decision that had been taken at the highest level. He took me aside and embracing me said, 'Young man, you are just like a son to me, you are making a terrible mistake. A civilian job is shaky, unlike the army where your career is assured. Besides, in a few days, we will be promoting you to lieutenant. I hope you will not regret this step.'

The die had been cast, however, and the next day a telegram was sent to my unit in Secunderabad, ordering them to prepare all the necessary papers for my discharge. My centre commander, Colonel Barve, was thunderstruck when he received that fateful telegram, and sadly broke the news to the other officers and jawans.

The unit had been home to me ever since I had joined as a raw recruit in 1953. It was the only family I knew, who had loved, nurtured and guided me through all the vicissitudes of life, encouraging and supporting me to fulfil my dream of being a world-class athlete. And now it was time to say goodbye, to leave my safe haven and enter a new, unfamiliar world .

It was a sad and poignant farewell. Colonel Barve addressed a huge assembly of sorrowful jawans and officers, saying that although he was deeply distressed by my decision to leave both the army and unit, he nevertheless would like to wish me good luck in my future endeavours. When it was my turn to speak, I could not find the words to express the heartfelt love and gratitude I felt for the people who stood before me. I only knew that I would never forget my unit and my colleagues and all the years I spent there. I recalled the tough life in the barracks, the early morning roll calls and hard labour, the hours I spent on the playing fields, the rigorous training schedule I had forced myself to endure, and all the kindness I had received from my officers, coaches and fellow soldiers. It was because of their confidence in me that I had risen from a nonentity to a celebrity. I ended my speech by appealing to Colonel Barve to produce many more Milkha Singhs, so that our unit could keep this tradition alive.

I was overwhelmed by the warmth of their affection, and by the generous gifts I received—a silver glass, silver thali, a beautiful embossed salver and a gold kara that I still treasure along with my memories of the EME Centre. But the transition was complete—my life in the army had ended and a new one as a civilian awaited me.